

Signorini's Problem

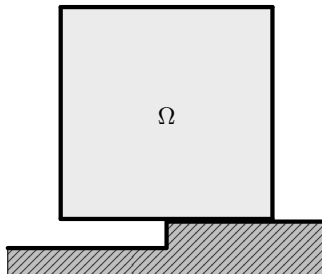
Max Stuthmann

March 16, 2026

- 1 Introduction – What's the Problem?
- 2 Geometrical and Physical Setup
 - Boundary Decomposition
 - Elasticity and Forces
 - Admissible Displacements
- 3 Energy Minimization
- 4 Weak Formulations
- 5 Strong Formulations
 - A Hybrid Formulation
 - Classical Strong Formulation

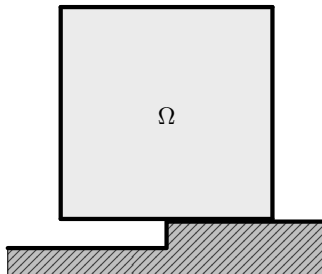
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- *Body:* $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$, $d \in \{2, 3\}$ open, bounded, connected with Lipschitz boundary $\Gamma := \partial\Omega$.



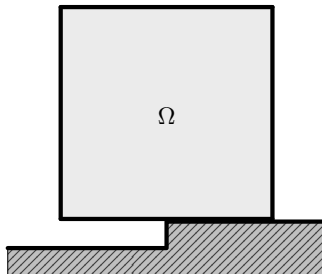
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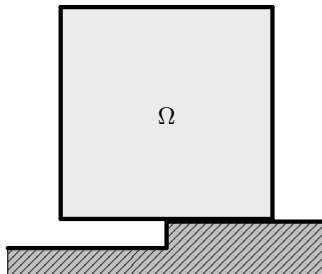
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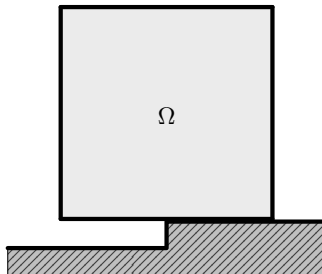
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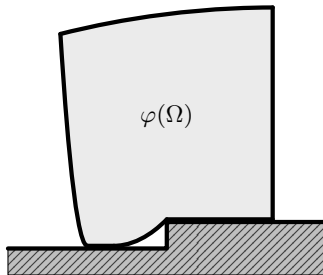
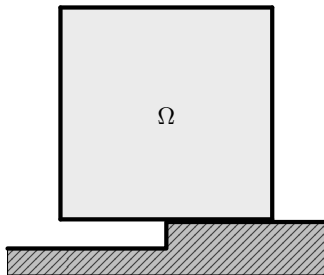
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- ▶ **Not in equilibrium configuration.**



What is to be found?

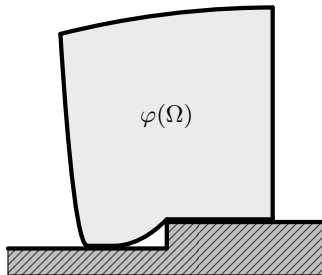
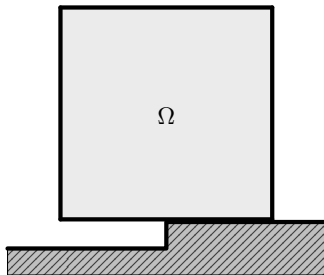
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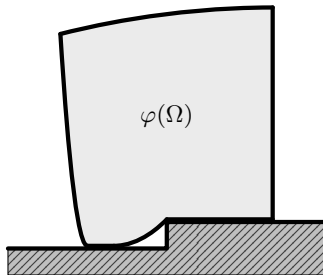
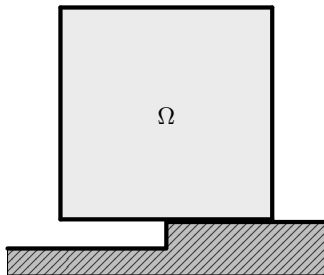


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- ▶ We aim to find the *displacement function* u .

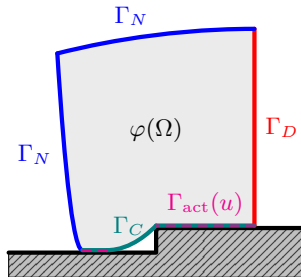
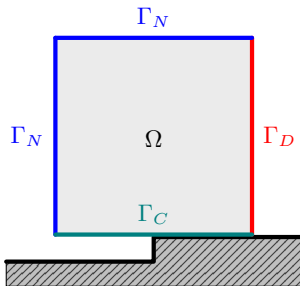


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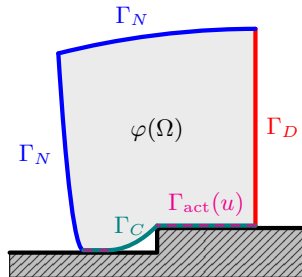
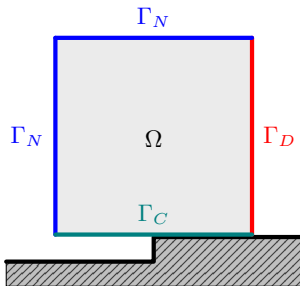
Boundary Decomposition and Preview on the Boundary Conditions

- Decompose $\Gamma = \partial\Omega$ into three relatively open and pairwise disjoint parts $\Gamma = \overline{\Gamma_D} \dot{\cup} \overline{\Gamma_N} \dot{\cup} \overline{\Gamma_C}$ with $|\Gamma_D|, |\Gamma_C| > 0$ and $|\Gamma_N| \geq 0$.



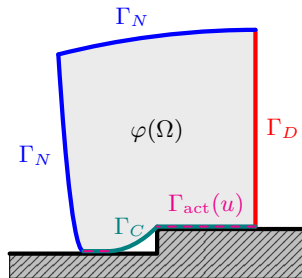
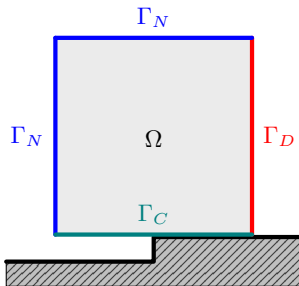
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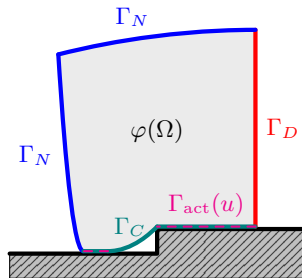
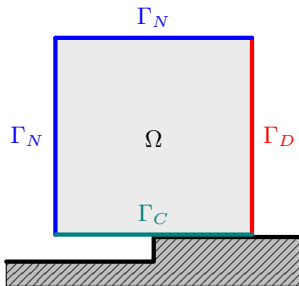
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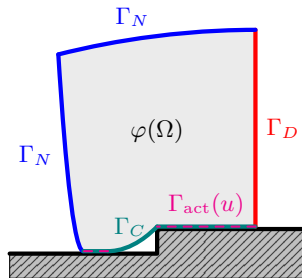
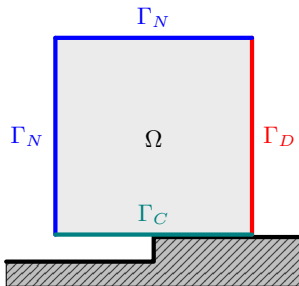
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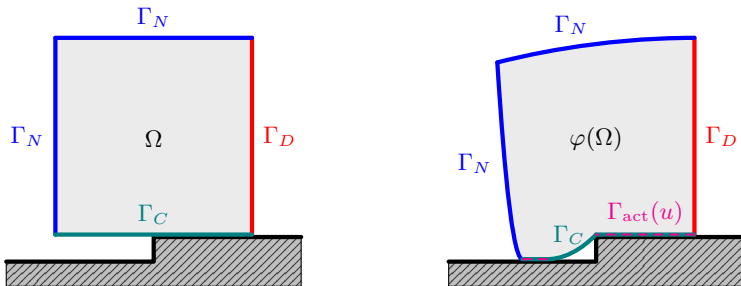
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- ▶ Rigid foundation can be describe by gap-function $g : \Gamma_C \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. We assume $g = 0$.



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Basic Notations on Sobolev Spaces

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- ▶ *Trace Theorem*: Restriction of smooth functions $\overline{\Omega} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d$ onto the boundary $\Gamma = \partial\Omega \in \mathcal{C}^{m,1}$ extends uniquely to a continuous surjective linear trace operator

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- ▶ For now, Ω is Lipschitz, i.e. $m = 0$ and we need $s = 1$, so

$$\gamma : H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \rightarrow H^{1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$$

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- If $\mathcal{A} : \Omega \rightarrow \mathcal{L}(\mathbb{S}^d; \mathbb{S}^d)$ is a fourth order tensor and $s \in \mathbb{S}^d$, we use the *double contraction*

$$s : \mathcal{A}(x) : s := \sum_{i=1}^d \sum_{j=1}^d \sum_{k=1}^d \sum_{l=1}^d \mathcal{A}_{ijkl}(x) s_{ij} s_{kl}.$$

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- ▶ $\mathcal{A}_{ijkl} \in L^\infty(\Omega)$ is sufficient for $s = 1$. Later on, we need more.

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- ▶ *Work = force · displacement:* The linear functional

$$\ell(v) := \int_{\Omega} f \cdot v \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds, \quad v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$$

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- ▶ *Equilibrium* between both: $a(u, v) = \ell(v) \quad \forall v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$.

Standard Properties of a and ℓ

Proposition

The symmetric bilinear form $a : V \times V \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ defined above is

- i) *bounded, i.e. for all $u, v \in V$ there exists $C_1 < \infty$ such that*

$$|a(u, v)| \leq C_1 \|u\|_{1,\Omega} \|v\|_{1,\Omega}.$$

- ii) *V -elliptic, i.e. for all $v \in V \setminus \{0\}$ there exist $C_2 > 0$ such that*

$$a(v, v) \geq C_2 \|v\|_{1,\Omega}^2.$$

Moreover, the linear functional ℓ defined above is bounded, i.e. for all $v \in V$ there exists $C_3 > 0$ such that

$$|\ell(v)| \leq C_3 \|v\|_{1,\Omega}.$$

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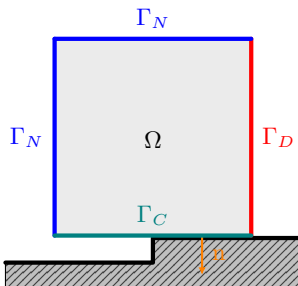
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Admissible Displacements and the Nonpenetration Constraint

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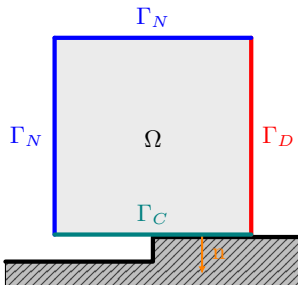


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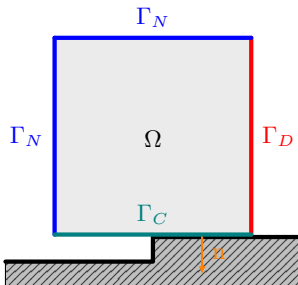


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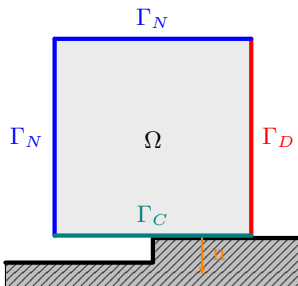


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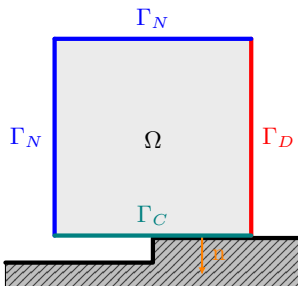


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Problem (Signorini's Problem – Energy Minimization)

$$\text{Find } u \in K \text{ such that: } \mathcal{J}(u) = \min_{v \in K} \mathcal{J}(v).$$

Proposition (Well-Posedness of Signorini's Problem)

There exists exactly one $u \in K$ that minimizes $\mathcal{J}$ over K . Moreover, the unique minimizer satisfies the a-priori bound

$$\|u\|_{1,\Omega} \leq \frac{2C_3}{C_2} \|\ell\|_{V'}.$$

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- ▶ Stability bound follows from V -ellipticity of a w.r.t. C_2 and boundedness of ℓ w.r.t. C_3 .

Proposition (First-order optimality condition on convex sets)

A function $u \in K$ minimizes $\mathcal{J}$ over K if and only if it satisfies the variational inequality

$$\mathcal{J}'(u)[v - u] = a(u, v - u) - \ell(v - u) \geq 0 \quad \forall v \in K.$$

Weak Formulations / Variational Inequality

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Problem (Signorini's Problem – Weak Formulation 2)

Find $u \in K$ such that:
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Content

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2 Geometrical and Physical Setup

3 Energy Minimization

4 Weak Formulations

5 Strong Formulations

- A Hybrid Formulation
- Classical Strong Formulation

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Normal Traces on $H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$

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- ▶ In the smooth case, $\gamma_{\mathbf{n}}(\tau)$ coincides with the classical traction $\tau \mathbf{n}$. We thus write $\tau \mathbf{n} = \gamma_{\mathbf{n}}(\tau)$.

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- ▶ Thus, we further assume $\sigma(u) \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$ which yields $\sigma(u)n := \gamma_n(\sigma(u)) \in H^{-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$.

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$$a(u, v) - \ell(v) = \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_\Gamma - \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds, \quad \forall v \in V.$$

A Hybrid Formulation

Problem (Signorini's Problem – Hybrid Formulation)

For given $f \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and $F \in L^2(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d)$, find $u \in K$ such that $\sigma(u) \in H(\text{div}; \Omega)$ and

$$\begin{cases} -\text{div } \sigma(u) = f & \text{a.e. in } \Omega, \end{cases} \quad (1a)$$

$$\begin{cases} \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_\Gamma = \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma u) \, ds, \end{cases} \quad (1b)$$

$$\begin{cases} \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_\Gamma \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds \quad \forall v \in K. \end{cases} \quad (1c)$$

Equivalence of Hybrid and Weak Formulation

Proposition (Equivalence of Hybrid and Weak Formulation)

Assume $\sigma(u) \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$. Then $u \in K$ solves the hybrid problem above if and only if it solves the weak problem

$$\text{Find } u \in K \text{ such that } a(u, v - u) \geq \ell(v - u) \quad \forall v \in K.$$

Proof: Hybrid $\Rightarrow$ Weak:

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Proof: Hybrid $\Rightarrow$ Weak:

- ▶ Subtract (1b) from (1c):

$$\langle \sigma(u)\mathbf{n}, \gamma(v - u) \rangle_{\Gamma} - \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma(v - u) \, ds \geq 0 \quad \forall v \in K.$$

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- ▶ Insert the identity from the above:

$$a(u, v - u) - \ell(v - u) \geq 0 \quad \forall v \in K,$$

i.e. the weak formulation.

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Proof: *Weak $\Rightarrow$ Hybrid (Bulk Equation):*

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► Let $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Then $u \pm t\varphi \in K$ for $|t| \ll 1$, hence the weak inequality implies

$$a(u, \varphi) = \ell(\varphi) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot \varphi \, dx = \langle f, \varphi \rangle \quad \forall \varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

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- ▶ The left hand side is

$$a(u, \varphi) = \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \varepsilon(\varphi) = \int_{\Omega} \sigma(u) : \nabla \varphi \, dx = \langle -\operatorname{div} \sigma(u), \varphi \rangle.$$

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- ▶ Thus, $-\operatorname{div} \sigma(u) = f$ in $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and by $\sigma(u) \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$, it holds in $L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ as well.

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- ▶ This is exactly (1b).

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► With the identity earlier, we have for all $v \in V$ that

$$a(u, v - u) = \langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma(v - u) \rangle_{\Gamma} + \int_{\Omega} f \cdot (v - u) \, dx \geq \ell(v - u) = \int_{\Omega} f \cdot (v - u) \, dx + \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma(v - u) \, ds$$

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- ▶ Subtracting volume term yields: $\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma(v - u) \rangle_{\Gamma} \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma(v - u) \, ds \quad \forall v \in V.$

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- ▶ This means

$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_{\Gamma} \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma v \, ds + \underbrace{\left[\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_{\Gamma} - \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot \gamma u \, ds \right]}_{=0} \quad \forall v \in V.$$

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Additional Regularity Assumptions and their Consequences

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- ▶ With $\sigma(u) = \mathcal{A} : \varepsilon(u)$, the stress tensor is now an operator $\sigma : H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d) \rightarrow H^{s-1}(\Omega; \mathbb{S}^d)$.

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- ▶ Furthermore, for $u \in H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ we have $\gamma u \in (H^{s-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d))$ with normal/tangential splitting

$$u_n := (\gamma u) \cdot n \in H^{s-1/2}(\Gamma) \quad \text{and} \quad u_t := \gamma u - u_n n \in H^{s-1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d).$$

Classical Strong Formulation under Additional Regularity

Problem (Signorini's Problem – Classical Strong Formulation)

For given $f \in L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ and $F \in L^2(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d)$ find $u \in H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ with $s > 3/2$ such that the small strain elasticity equations

$$\begin{cases} -\operatorname{div} \sigma(u) = f & \text{in } \Omega, \\ u = 0 & \text{on } \Gamma_D, \\ t(u) = F & \text{on } \Gamma_N, \end{cases} \quad \begin{array}{l} (2a) \\ (2b) \\ (2c) \end{array}$$

and the contact conditions

$$\begin{cases} u_n \leq 0 & \text{on } \Gamma_C, \\ \sigma_n(u) \leq 0 & \text{on } \Gamma_C, \\ \sigma_n(u) u_n = 0 & \text{on } \Gamma_C, \\ \sigma_t(u) = 0 & \text{on } \Gamma_C \end{cases} \quad \begin{array}{l} (3a) \\ (3b) \\ (3c) \\ (3d) \end{array}$$

hold.

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- ▶ *Frictionless contact* $\sigma_t(u) = 0$ on Γ_C : Foundation does not exert any tangential force on the body.

Proposition (Equivalence of Strong and Hybrid Formulation)

Let $u \in H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ with $s > 3/2$. Then u solves the strong problem if and only if it solves the hybrid problem.

Proof: *Strong $\implies$ Hybrid:*

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Let $u \in H^s(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ with $s > 3/2$. Then u solves the strong problem if and only if it solves the hybrid problem.

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- ▶ This means, $\sigma(u) \in H(\operatorname{div}; \Omega)$.

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► We want to show

$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_{\Gamma} = \int_{\Gamma} t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds \quad \forall v \in K.$$

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$$\int_{\Gamma} t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds = \underbrace{\int_{\Gamma_D} t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds}_{=0 \text{ since } \gamma v=0 \text{ on } \Gamma_D} + \int_{\Gamma_N} \underbrace{t(u)}_{=F \text{ on } \Gamma_C} \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds + \int_{\Gamma_C} t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds.$$

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► With $t(u) = \sigma_n(u)n + \sigma_t(u)$ and $\gamma v = v_n n + v_t$, we have

$$t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) = \sigma_n(u) v_n + \underbrace{\sigma_t(u) \cdot v_t}_{=0 \text{ on } \Gamma_C \text{ since } \sigma_t(u)=0 \text{ on } \Gamma_C}.$$

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- Since $v \in K$, we have $v_n \leq 0$ on Γ_C and by (3b), we have $\sigma_n(u) \leq 0$ on Γ_C .
- Thus $\sigma_n(u) v_n \geq 0$ on Γ_C and thus

$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma v \rangle_\Gamma \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds \quad \forall v \in V.$$

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$$\langle \sigma(u)n, \gamma u \rangle_{\Gamma} = \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot (\gamma u) \, ds + \underbrace{\int_{\Gamma_C} \sigma_n(u) u_n \, ds}_{=0 \text{ since } \sigma_n(u) u_n = 0 \text{ on } \Gamma_C} \quad .$$

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- ▶ Since $u \in K$, we have $u = 0$ on Γ_D and $u_n \leq 0$ on Γ_C .
- ▶ It remains to prove $t(u) = F$ on Γ_N and the remaining contact conditions.

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- ▶ Let $g \in H^{1/2}(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d)$ such that $\text{Ext}_0(g) \in H^{1/2}(\Gamma; \mathbb{R}^d)$, i.e. $g \in H_{00}^{1/2}(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d)$. Then there exists $v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ such that

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- ▶ Then $\pm v \in K$.
- ▶ Plug $\pm v$ into hybrid inequality:

$$\int_{\Gamma_N} t(u) \cdot g \, ds \geq \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot g \, ds, \quad - \int_{\Gamma_N} t(u) \cdot g \, ds \geq - \int_{\Gamma_N} F \cdot f \, ds.$$

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- ▶ Therefore,

$$\int_{\Gamma_N} (t(u) - F) \cdot g \, ds = 0 \quad \forall g \in H_{00}^{1/2}(\Gamma_N; \mathbb{R}^d) \quad \implies \quad t(u) = F \text{ on } \Gamma_N.$$

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- ▶ With $t(u) = F$ on Γ_N , the hybrid inequality yields $\int_{\Gamma_C} t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds \geq 0$ for all $v \in K$.

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- ▶ With $t(u) = \sigma_n(u)\mathbf{n} + \sigma_t(u)$ this means

$$\int_{\Gamma_C} (\sigma_n(u)\mathbf{n} + \sigma_t(u)) \cdot g_t \, ds = \int_{\Gamma_C} \sigma_n(u) \underbrace{(\mathbf{n} \cdot g_t)}_{=0} \, ds + \int_{\Gamma_C} \sigma_t(u) \cdot g_t \, ds = 0.$$

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- ▶ Again, $\int_{\Gamma_C} t(u) \cdot (\gamma v) \, ds \geq 0$ for all $v \in K$.
- ▶ Let $\eta \in H_{00}^{1/2}(\Gamma_C)$ with $\eta \leq 0$ on Γ_C and choose $v \in H^1(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^d)$ with $(\gamma v)|_{\Gamma_C} = \eta n$ and $(\gamma v)|_{\Gamma_N} = 0$ and $(\gamma v)|_{\Gamma_D} = 0$.

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- ▶ Then, $v_n = (\gamma v) \cdot \mathbf{n} = \eta \leq 0$, i.e. $v \in K$ and $\int_{\Gamma_C} t(u) \cdot (\eta \mathbf{n}) \, ds \geq 0$.

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- ▶ Then, $v_n = (\gamma v) \cdot \mathbf{n} = \eta \leq 0$, i.e. $v \in K$ and $\int_{\Gamma_C} t(u) \cdot (\eta \mathbf{n}) \, ds \geq 0$.
- ▶ With $t(u) = \sigma_n(u) \mathbf{n} + \sigma_t(u)$ and $\sigma_t(u) = 0$ on Γ_C , we have

$$\int_{\Gamma_C} \sigma_n(u) \eta \, ds \geq 0 \quad \forall \eta \in H_{00}^{1/2}(\Gamma_C), \eta \leq 0.$$

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- ▶ With $t(u) = \sigma_n(u) n + \sigma_t(u)$ and $\sigma_t(u) = 0$ on Γ_C , we have

$$\int_{\Gamma_C} t(u) \cdot \gamma u \, ds = \int_{\Gamma_C} \underbrace{\sigma_n(u)}_{\leq 0} \underbrace{u_n}_{\leq 0} \, ds = 0.$$

□